
Religion

An Open-Source Summary

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June 14, 2026

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Class summaries are handwritten and some are notebooklm generated.

1 Class - 2

1.1 Jensen 2014

Jeppe Sinding Jensen's work explores the academic conceptualization of religion, emphasizing that **“religion” is not a “given” objective fact, but rather an analytical term** constructed by scholars to categorize, investigate, and interpret human behavior. Because the borders of what constitutes a religion are fuzzy, Jensen advocates for a **polythetic definition**, meaning religions are grouped by a “family resemblance” of shared elements (like rituals, ideas about the sacred, or ethics) rather than a single, universal characteristic.

To demonstrate how the study of religion is inherently theory-dependent, Jensen outlines **five influential definitions** that represent major intellectual “turns” in the field:

- **Émile Durkheim (Sociological):** Views religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices focused on sacred things, which functions to unite individuals into a single moral community.
- **Sigmund Freud (Psychoanalytic):** Takes a highly critical stance, defining religion as an illusion and a “universal obsessional neurosis” stemming from immature psychological processes and a longing for a father figure.
- **Paul Tillich (Theological/Existential):** Focuses on faith as an “ultimate concern” that provides deep cognitive and emotional meaning, helping humans cope with the existential conditions of their lives.
- **Clifford Geertz (Cultural/Anthropological):** Defines religion as a cultural system of symbols that establish pervasive moods, motivations, and conceptions of the world, making them seem uniquely realistic.
- **Pascal Boyer (Cognitive/Evolutionary):** Argues that religion is an evolutionary by-product (a “spandrel”) that arises from the human brain's natural propensity to pay attention to counter-intuitive representations, such as invisible agents or gods.

Beyond these definitions, Jensen traces the **history of how religion has been studied** and critiqued, which is deeply tied to the rise of Western modernity:

- **The Enlightenment and Reason:** Thinkers like David Hume and John Locke shifted the focus toward naturalistic explanations of religion, doubting scriptural miracles, and advocating for the separation of religion from politics. Deists sought to retain a rationalized, moral version of religion compatible with the laws of nature.
- **Romanticism vs. Positivism:** In contrast to Enlightenment rationality, Romantics like Friedrich Schleiermacher defined religion by individual intuition, emotion, and a feeling of “absolute dependence”. Conversely, positivists like Auguste Comte argued that human intellect would outgrow theology and be replaced entirely by scientific, “positive” knowledge.
- **Radical Critiques:** In the 19th century, Feuerbach labeled religion as a psychological projection, Karl Marx viewed it as the “opium of the people” functioning as a sedative for societal oppression, and Friedrich Nietzsche attacked it as a fraudulent system used to exercise power.

Finally, Jensen breaks down how **different academic disciplines approach religion today**:

- **Intellectualism and History:** Early anthropologists like Edward Burnett Tylor and James George Frazer viewed religion as an early, flawed attempt by humans to explain the cosmos and manipulate nature. Meanwhile, the “history of religions” emerged by applying rigorous, secular historical and philological methods to sacred texts rather than treating them as divine revelation.

- **Individual vs. Collective:** The study of religion split into investigating the **individual** experience through the psychology of religion (figures like William James and Carl Jung) and the **collective** experience through sociology and anthropology, treating religion as structured systems and “social facts” similar to language.
- **Evolutionary Science:** Modern debates weigh whether religion is merely an accidental, non-adaptive outcome of how the human brain evolved (cognitive science), or if it provided an evolutionary advantage by promoting morality, group cohesion, and survival (evolutionary biology and moral psychology).

1.2 Martin 2017

Craig Martin argues that the concept of “religion” cannot be neutrally or objectively defined because its definition is inherently political, socially constructed, and tied to specific human interests. Rather than asking “What is religion?”, Martin suggests we should ask, “Whose interests are being served by this definition?”.

To illustrate this, Martin compares defining religion to defining “wetlands” or “yoga”. For example, in Missouri, yoga enthusiasts successfully argued that yoga *was* a religion to avoid state taxes. However, in California, yoga advocates argued it *was not* a religion so it could be taught in public schools without violating the separation of church and state. In both cases, the definition was manipulated to serve a specific agenda.

Martin traces the problematic history of how “religion” has been defined over time:

- **Pre-modern Anachronisms:** Prior to the Protestant Reformation, there was no concept of a “religious” sphere separated from politics and everyday life. Translating ancient words (like the Latin *religio* or Arabic *din*) as “religion” is anachronistic, as these terms meant “custom,” “law,” or “reverence,” not a private institution.
- **A “Useful Fiction” for Peace:** The modern idea of religion as a private, spiritual matter separate from the state was invented by figures like Martin Luther and John Locke. This jurisdictional split was a “useful lie” designed to stop the violent wars between Catholics and Protestants and establish political tolerance, even though churches continued to be highly involved in politics.
- **Colonialism and Chauvinism:** In the 18th and 19th centuries, Europeans used definitions of religion to rank cultures on an evolutionary scale, placing Christianity at the top. Labeling other cultures as having “primitive” or “backward” religions was used to justify imperialism, colonization, and slavery.
- **Christian Privilege:** Even modern scholars who attempt to be neutral often use Protestant Christianity as the “ideal type,” expecting all religions to have a founder, sacred texts, doctrines, and rituals. This bias has historically disenfranchised groups like Native Americans, who initially lacked religious freedom protections because their practices didn’t look enough like Christianity to be legally recognized as a “religion”.
- **The Myth of Irrationality:** Today, religion is often defined as inherently “irrational” in contrast to “rational” science or the secular state. Martin points out the hypocrisy in this, noting that violence committed by groups labeled “religious” (like Al Qaeda) is quickly condemned as irrational, while massive civilian casualties caused by secular nation-states are often justified as rational or necessary.

Ultimately, Martin argues that **finding a perfect, universal definition of religion is impossible**. Colloquial usage lumps together completely dissimilar things simply because of historical habit. If we try to define religion by a lowest common denominator—such as a “belief system,” a focus on the “supernatural,” or a search for the “meaning of life”—the definition inevitably includes things not typically considered religions (like Marxism, American nationalism, or even a Metallica fan club) or excludes traditions we normally count as religions (like atheistic forms of Buddhism).

Because “religion” carries so much historical and normative baggage, and because “religious” cultures function in the exact same ways as “non-religious” cultures, Martin concludes that it is analytically unhelpful to draw fundamental distinctions between the two. For scholars, the study of religion is ultimately just the study of culture.

2 Class - 3

2.1 Fox 2009

Judith Fox's chapter explores the highly contentious debate among sociologists regarding **secularization**, noting that disagreements persist largely due to conflicting definitions and deep ideological assumptions. While early sociologists defined secularization as the declining public significance of religion, the concept is complicated by debates over whether this decline is irreversible, cyclical, or merely a shift from public to private belief.

To explain these divergent views, Fox traces the theoretical roots of the debate back to the Enlightenment's faith in scientific rationality and the foundational theories of Max Weber and Émile Durkheim:

- **Max Weber** argued that the rise of rationalization and modern bureaucracy would lead to the **"disenchantment"** of the world, gradually pushing religion out of public life and into the private sphere.
- **Émile Durkheim**, conversely, believed that religion serves an essential public function by maintaining social cohesion. He argued that while specific religious dogmas might die out, **religion itself would never disappear**; it would simply evolve into new forms and symbols.

Fox then outlines the progression of the **secularization debate** through several key sociological models:

- **The Classic Thesis (Bryan Wilson):** Building on Weber, Wilson argued in the 1960s that modernizing processes inevitably cause religious institutions to lose their social significance. He used statistics to show a decline in religious practice in Britain. While acknowledging that church membership remained high in the United States, Wilson dismissed this as an "acculturated" form of religion where attendance was merely a tool for forging American social identity, rather than deep religious commitment.
- **The 'Religious Economies' Model (Stark and Bainbridge):** Taking a more Durkheimian approach, these scholars argued that human beings have a constant demand for supernatural "compensators" to solve the central problems of existence. They posited that **secularization is self-limiting and cyclical**; as established religions become too rational and secular, they leave a void that is quickly filled by new sects and cults.
- **The 'Rational Choice' Model (Stark and Iannaccone):** This economic model suggests that **religious pluralism acts as a free market** that stimulates religious enthusiasm. Therefore, competitive religious environments like the United States naturally produce high religiosity, whereas places with historically state-sponsored religious monopolies, like Europe, suffer from low religious demand.

Fox highlights that scholars like Sharon Hanson have severely criticized both sides of this debate for talking past one another with incompatible definitions, relying on unverified historical data, and exhibiting a heavily **"christo-centric" bias**—falsely equating the decline of institutional Christianity in the West with the disappearance of religion altogether. Because of these issues, many scholars are now shifting their focus away from secularization and instead studying the diverse landscape of modern **religious pluralism**, noting that people today may be "believing without belonging".

Ultimately, Fox concludes that **secularization theory is practically impossible to test or refute empirically**. Relying on Karl Popper's philosophy of science, she points out that advocates of secularization can always dismiss contrary evidence—such as the rise of new religious movements—as temporary setbacks or mere "superstition". Because the theory's core tenets are so deeply interwoven with the Enlightenment ideals that gave birth to the social sciences, Fox suggests that secularization functions less like a rigorous scientific theory and more like an unfalsifiable ideology.

2.2 Hanson 1997

Expanding on the critique mentioned in Judith Fox's article, Sharon Hanson's 1997 paper argues that the sociological debate surrounding the secularization thesis is deeply flawed because theorists are constantly **"talking at cross purposes"**. She identifies two major reasons for this confusion: a failure to clearly define key terms and a severe lack of rigor in how sociologists use historical data.

To resolve the definitional ambiguity, Hanson suggests dividing secularization arguments into two distinct categories:

- **The Broad Approach:** Focuses on whether religion has lost its social significance at the level of the **social system** (e.g., its influence on politics, legitimation, and power relations).
- **The Narrow Approach:** Focuses on whether religion has lost its significance at the level of **individual consciousness** or personal piety.

Hanson points out that theorists constantly mix these approaches up. For example, a scholar might argue that secularization is happening at a broad, societal level, but then rely almost entirely on church attendance statistics—which are actually evidence for the narrow, individual approach.

Furthermore, Hanson heavily critiques how sociologists "raid" the work of historians without understanding the methodological limits of the data they are using. Much of the secularization debate revolves around comparing modern times to a medieval **"golden age of faith"**. Hanson demonstrates how major scholars misuse historical records to make their points:

- **Stark & Iannaccone's Errors:** To prove their "supply-side" theory that religious participation hasn't declined but merely fluctuates, Stark and Iannaccone attempt to demolish the idea of historical piety. Hanson exposes how they carelessly misused data from historian Peter Laslett regarding the village of Clayworth. They misdated the data to the late 18th century instead of the 17th century, misinterpreted the statistics by failing to account for village demographics (like babies who couldn't take communion), and relied on an outdated edition of the text, completely missing Laslett's later revisions.
- **Steve Bruce's Simplifications:** On the opposing side, Hanson criticizes Steve Bruce for relying too simplistically on quantitative historical statistics. Bruce compares 19th-century church attendance with modern data to prove secularization, but Hanson argues this is an irrelevant comparison because the very nature and definition of "piety" has drastically changed between then and now.

Ultimately, Hanson concludes that unless sociologists establish precise boundaries for their definitions and start applying historical data with much greater care, the secularization thesis will remain a confused, unworkable, and misleading concept.

3 Class - 4

No article

4 Class - 5

4.1 Casanova 2011

In his article, José Casanova proposes a fundamental analytical framework that breaks down the discussion of secularity into three distinct concepts: **"the secular," "secularization," and "secularism"**. By separating these terms, he aims to

better understand modern world-historical processes without reducing them to a single, inevitable path of development.

Here is a summary of the three core concepts explored in the article:

1. The Secular

Casanova traces the concept of “the secular” back to the Latin term *saeculum*, which originally meant an indefinite period of time but evolved in medieval Christendom into a binary system separating the “religious” (monastic life) from the “secular” (the profane world).

- **The Paradox of the Secular:** Originally, the secular was simply what was left over outside of the religious sphere. Paradoxically, in the modern age, the secular has come to be seen as reality *tout court* (the whole of reality)—a natural substratum that remains when religion is removed, rendering religion a “superfluous additive”.
- **Ways of Being Secular:** Casanova outlines three different ways people experience being secular: (a) *mere secularity*, where living without religion is just one normal option among others; (b) *self-sufficient and exclusive secularity*, where living without religion is the taken-for-granted, unquestioned norm; and (c) *secularist secularity*, where individuals feel actively liberated from religion, which they view as essential for human flourishing.

2. Secularizations

“Secularization” generally refers to the historical processes and transformations where “the religious” and “the secular” (such as the state, science, and economy) become differentiated. Casanova argues that the traditional theory of secularization should be disaggregated into three separate subtheses to be properly understood:

- **Institutional differentiation:** The separation of secular spheres from religious institutions.
- **The decline of religion:** The progressive drop in religious beliefs and practices.
- **The privatization of religion:** The confinement of religion to the private sphere. Casanova notes that while Europe experienced all three processes as a single interconnected development, the United States is a prime example of secular differentiation occurring *without* a decline in religion or its strict confinement to the private sphere. Furthermore, he cautions against viewing secularization as a universal global process, emphasizing that it is rooted in Western Christian history and was globalized largely through European colonialism.

3. Secularisms

“Secularism” refers to the modern worldviews, ideologies, and state projects regarding the separation of religion and society. Casanova distinguishes between two primary forms of secularism:

- **Secularism as Statecraft:** This is a political principle of separating state and religion to protect the freedom of conscience for all citizens and ensure equal democratic participation. Political secularism can actually view religion positively as a moral good, so long as it remains in its differentiated sphere.
- **Secularism as Ideology:** This involves progressive philosophies that relegate religion to an irrational, superseded stage of human development that should be banished from the public sphere. Casanova observes a “stadial consciousness” among many Europeans, who view secularism as a sign of modern maturity and religion as inherently backward and “intolerant”. He notes the irony in this view, as it often selectively ignores the massive violence caused by secular ideologies in the 20th century.

Ultimately, Casanova argues that strict secular separation of church and state is not an end in itself, but rather a means to protect the “free exercise” of religion and ensure equal rights within a democracy.

4.2 Shakman Hurd 2008

This chapter from *Varieties of Secularism* challenges the conventional assumption in international relations that secularism is merely the natural, neutral separation of religion and politics. Instead, the author argues that **secularism is a socially constructed organizing principle of modern politics that exercises significant power by defining the boundaries between the sacred and the secular.**

The text identifies two primary trajectories of secularism that prestructure discourse in international relations, both of which share philosophical roots in Immanuel Kant's attempt to replace religious sectarianism with a universal, "rational religion".

Laicism

The first trajectory, laicism, views religion as an irrational adversary to modern politics and seeks to force it entirely out of the public sphere. Rooted in Enlightenment critiques, laicism operates on the assumption that religious traditions are obsolete and that a singular, rational moral order should guide public life.

- **Impact on International Relations:** Laicism profoundly influences realist, liberal, and materialist theories of international relations, which operate on the "Westphalian presumption" that religion was successfully privatized following the creation of the modern state. It also underpins modernization theory, which treats the exclusion of religion from governance as a universally applicable science.
- **Theological Nature of Laicism:** The author argues that laicism is not actually neutral; it enacts its own form of theological discourse by aggressively defining what constitutes "religion"—often characterizing it as violent or undemocratic—in order to legitimize the secular public sphere as the exclusive domain of reason and justice.

Judeo-Christian Secularism

The second trajectory, Judeo-Christian secularism, positions religion differently. It views the Judeo-Christian tradition not as an adversary, but as the foundational source of unity, identity, and democratic values in Western civilization. Rather than banishing religion, it celebrates the Christian origins of the secular state, asserting that a shared adherence to this religious tradition provides the ethical consensus necessary for popular government.

- **Impact on International Relations:** This form of secularism frequently fuels the "clash of civilizations" narrative popularized by thinkers like Samuel Huntington. It frames the separation of church and state as a uniquely Western achievement and divides the world into those who share this Judeo-Christian common ground and those who do not, often leading to aggressive foreign policies designed to defend Western uniqueness against external threats, particularly Islam.

Conclusion

Ultimately, the author concludes that **neither form of secularism is universally applicable; both are historically contingent constructs carved out of the specific theopolitical history of Latin Christendom.** By attempting to permanently fix the definition of religion and dictate its proper relationship to the state, both laicism and Judeo-Christian secularism marginalize non-Western perspectives and prematurely shut down political contestation over how societies can structure themselves.

4.3 Taylor 1998

In "Modes of Secularism," Charles Taylor explores the historical development of secularism, explains why it is functionally necessary for modern democracies, and proposes a specific model of secularism as the only viable path forward for today's highly diverse societies.

Here is a summary of the core themes in Taylor's essay:

1. The Historical Roots and Two Early Strategies

Taylor notes that secularism originated in Western Christendom (from the Latin *saeculum*, meaning ordinary or profane time) and emerged as a practical solution to the horrific Wars of Religion, aiming to find a basis for peaceful coexistence. Historically, this took two different forms:

- **The Common Ground Strategy:** This approach sought to establish political order based on doctrines shared by all Christian sects, or at least all theists (such as Natural Law). However, this strategy breaks down as society diversifies to include non-believers, Muslims, and other faiths, because the “common ground” inevitably shrinks.
- **The Independent Ethic Strategy:** Thinkers like Grotius and Hobbes attempted to abstract political morality from religion entirely, basing it instead on undeniable facts of human condition, rationality, and sociability. While this aims for neutrality, Taylor points out that religious believers often perceive this “independent ethic” as a rival, partisan worldview (a form of militant unbelief), leading to cultural friction and making secularism feel like an alien imposition, especially in non-Western contexts.

2. The Democratic Imperative for Secularism

Taylor argues that secularism is not optional; it is an inescapable requirement of the modern democratic state. Modern nation-states are “imagined communities” characterized by “direct-access” horizontal relationships between equal citizens, rather than the hierarchical structures of the past. Because a democracy relies on collective self-rule, it requires a strong sense of common identity, patriotism, and commitment from its citizens. However, if this shared identity is tied to a specific religion (Taylor uses the rise of Hindu nationalism in India as a prime example), minority groups are fundamentally excluded from the “sovereign people”. This exclusion destroys democratic legitimacy and can lead to severe consequences, including forced emigration or ethnic cleansing. Therefore, secularism is functionally indispensable to bond religiously diverse citizens together in a democracy.

3. The Solution: An “Overlapping Consensus”

Because both the “common ground” and “independent ethic” models fail in highly diverse modern societies, Taylor advocates for a third approach, borrowing John Rawls's concept of an “overlapping consensus”.

- In this model, citizens converge on a shared set of politico-ethical principles and goods (such as human rights, equality, and popular sovereignty).
- Crucially, the state does not demand that everyone share the same *underlying justification* for these principles. For instance, a Christian might support the right to life because humans are made in the image of God, an Enlightenment thinker might support it based on rational human agency, and a Buddhist might support it based on the ethics of non-violence.

By focusing on shared principles rather than demanding a universally agreed-upon philosophical or religious foundation, Taylor concludes that the overlapping consensus is the only viable form of secularism available to successfully manage the deep diversity of the modern world.

5 Class - 6

5.1 Scott 2007

Joan Wallach Scott's *The Politics of the Veil* examines the underlying anxieties that led to the 2004 French law banning “conspicuous” religious signs in public schools, a law primarily aimed at the Muslim headscarf. Scott argues that the veil

was not simply a religious garment, but became a screen onto which the French republic projected its deep-seated fears about immigration, national identity, and changing gender roles.

Here is a summary of the core arguments and themes in Scott's work:

The Timeline of the Controversies

Scott traces the *affaires des foulards* (headscarf controversies) through three key eruptions that demonstrate a progressive hardening of the French government's stance:

- **1989:** Three Muslim girls were expelled from a middle school in Creil for refusing to remove their headscarves in the name of *laïcité* (French secularism). At this time, the Council of State ruled that wearing religious signs was not incompatible with secularism, provided they did not constitute acts of provocation or proselytism, leaving room for accommodation.
- **1994:** Education Minister François Bayrou attempted to ban all “ostentatious” signs of religious affiliation, leading to the expulsion of 69 girls, though this decree was frequently overturned by the courts.
- **2003–2004:** Following intense media attention—such as the expulsion of the Lévy sisters, who had converted to Islam—and a government commission headed by Bernard Stasi, the government ultimately passed a law in 2004 definitively banning the headscarf in public schools, ending any room for mediation.

Political Motivations: Co-opting the Far Right

Scott argues that the 2004 ban was not a reaction to an objective worsening of religious extremism in schools, but rather a response to domestic political pressures. **Successive mainstream governments utilized the headscarf issue to capture the anti-immigrant vote and counter the rising popularity of Jean-Marie Le Pen's far-right National Front party.** By focusing on a few girls wearing headscarves, politicians were able to substitute a symbolic gesture for the much harder task of addressing the actual social, economic, and racial discrimination faced by North African immigrants.

The Clash with French Republican Universalism

A major driving force behind the ban was the ideology of French republicanism, which relies on **abstract individualism**. This ideology dictates that to be equal citizens, individuals must strip away their ethnic, religious, and social differences in the public sphere to achieve “sameness”. Consequently, French republicans viewed the headscarf as a dangerous symbol of *communautarisme* (communalism)—a refusal to assimilate into a singular, homogenous national culture.

Sexuality and the “Open” vs. “Covered” Gender Systems

In Chapter 5, Scott explores how the language of the ban—specifically the choice to outlaw “conspicuous” or “ostentatious” signs—revealed a hidden preoccupation with sexuality. Scott contrasts two idealized gender systems to explain the intense French reaction:

- **The French “Open” System:** In France, women's emancipation and equality are culturally equated with the visibility of the female body and sexual availability. The exposure of the body is positively valued as a hallmark of liberty.
- **The Islamic “Covered” System:** In contrast, the Islamic tradition recognizes sexuality as a disruptive force that poses risks to social and political order. Modesty and the covering of the body are used to manage these libidinal energies and prevent sexual temptation.

For French observers, the veil was not seen as a sign of modesty, but rather as something perverse and sexually abnormal. **French politicians and feminists interpreted the veil as an aggressive rejection of French gender norms and a denial of men's “natural” prerogative to look at women's bodies.** President Jacques Chirac even described the veil as a “kind of aggression”. Some extreme commentators compared the psychological impact of the veil to genital mutilation, arguing

it completely alienated young girls from their femininity, which in the French system is conferred by male desire and visual stimulation.

The Psychology of Denial

Scott concludes that the obsessive focus on saving Muslim women from their “oppressive” culture served as a convenient distraction for France. By pointing to Islam as the ultimate source of sexism, **French feminists and politicians engaged in a “psychology of denial,” allowing them to ignore the ongoing gender inequalities, wage discrimination, and domestic violence within their own borders.** Ultimately, the headscarf ban was a way for France to assert the absolute superiority of its own civilization and naturalize its specific cultural approach to sex and equality.

5.2 Scott 2018

Based on the provided excerpts from Joan Wallach Scott’s 2018 book *Sex and Secularism*, the article challenges the popular contemporary assumption that secularism inherently guarantees gender equality. Scott argues that this association is a historically false, politically motivated invention used primarily to assert Western superiority over Islam, while distracting from ongoing gender disparities within Western societies.

Here is a summary of the core arguments:

The False History of Secularism and Gender Equality

Scott approaches secularism genealogically, viewing it not as a fixed definition but as a discourse that changes depending on its political context. She points out that when the concept of secularism emerged in the 18th and 19th centuries, the separation of church and state actually relied on **gender inequality**. Western modernity assigned women to a feminized, private sphere of family and religion, while reserving the rational, public realms of politics and economics for men. Gender equality was completely absent from the founding documents of Western democracies. It was only in the late 20th century, amidst the “clash of civilizations” rhetoric, that gender equality was retroactively claimed as a primordial value of secularism.

Christian Secularism and the “Muslim Question”

The modern discourse of secularism has deep roots in colonial history and is heavily intertwined with Christian exceptionalism. By contrasting an allegedly enlightened, sexually liberated West against a supposedly repressed, misogynistic Islamic “other,” secularism functions to justify claims of white, Western, and Christian racial superiority. Scott compares the modern stigmatization of Muslims in Europe to the 19th-century “Jewish Question,” arguing that a racialized view of Islamic culture is now used to portray Muslims as fundamentally incompatible with European democratic life.

Sexual Emancipation vs. True Equality

In the chapter titled “Sexual Emancipation,” Scott critiques the contemporary Western tendency to conflate gender equality with sexual freedom. She observes that in modern secular discourse, human agency is heavily reduced to the fulfillment of sexual desire. Consequently, emancipation is often narrowly equated with the public exposure of the female body and the freedom to act as a consumer.

- **The “Covered” vs. “Uncovered” Binary:** Western discourse relies on a strict opposition between “covered” Muslim women, who are deemed sexually repressed and trapped in the past, and “uncovered” Western women, who are considered autonomous and liberated.
- **The Illusion of Freedom:** Scott notes that the Western “liberated” ideal often simply translates to the freedom to conform to conventional, market-driven norms of femininity that cater to male desire. She argues that pushing

Muslim women to “unveil” is closely linked to capitalist demands that women participate in the market as both consumers and commodities.

- **A Distraction from Structural Inequality:** Scott stresses that historically, emancipation (the lifting of formal legal restraints) is not the same thing as substantive equality. By focusing obsessively on sexual desire and the visibility of women’s bodies as the ultimate metric of freedom, Western nations create a convenient distraction from deeply rooted structural inequalities—such as wage disparities, glass ceilings, domestic violence, and lack of social support—that continue to affect women globally.

Ultimately, Scott concludes that secularism operates as a polemical discourse that uses the language of gender equality to define national borders, perpetuate racial hierarchies, and mask the unresolved challenges of gender inequality within the West itself.

5.3 Summary of Lecture

France in the 90’s, the “laïcité” debate

1989:

- **Ernest Chénier** → Principal in a school who expelled 3 hijabi.
- Council of State (highest instance): wearing religious is okay as long it is not an “act of pressure, provocation, proselytism, or propaganda” → NOT incompatible with laïcité BUT school must decide case by case

1994:

- **Bayrou** → Minister of Education at the time
- BANS all signs of religious affiliation → they are intrinsically part of proselytize
- 69 girls expelled
- Council of state overturns it → Back to 89

2003:

- **Alma & Lila Lévy** → 2 french girls converted to Islam
- **Chirac** → French President → Ask Stasi for a commission to examine the religious signs ban
 - **March 2024:** Ban all religious signs besides small one (no more kippa, hijab, or cross)

2009:

- Nicolas Sarkozy → French President instates a commission for Muslims for their cult
- stated the burqa would not be tolerated, framing it not as a religious issue, but as an affront to women’s freedom, dignity, and a modern form of “enslavement”

Now:

- Debate motivated by the rise of populism far right (Rassemblement national/Lepen) takes that debate
- Debate is much deeper:
 - Security issue
 - Freedom and men’s control over woman → autonomous self
 - Islam and France’s culture and traditions

Scott:

- Racism:
 - Rooted in the north african colonialism of france and systematic marginalization of muslim immigrants

- Secularism + Individualism:
 - “Liberté,Égalité,Fraternité” → “Freedom, Equality, Brotherhood”
 - Rooted in French identity to be free
- Larger social issues + Sexuality
 - French → openness; Islam → modesty

Behind the debate:

- Clash between sex and sexuality → France and Islam have 2 views:
 - France: Open: Woman must and can be sexualized
 - * Putting a veil is seen as a restriction on woman and man’s own desire and sexuality
 - * Sexual promiscuity and freedom is seen as liberty
 - * **Psychology of denial:** We assume that even though there a sexual difference, **they can be ignored** and do not matter in a free society
 - Islam: Covered: modest and sexual *unavailable*
 - * **Psychology of recognition:** There are **differences between male and female** AND THUS we should avoid that sexuality disrupts the public space and keep it in **private sphere** rather than public

Sex and Secularism:

- Secularism = freedom + gender equality ?
 1. Gender equality **NEVER** been at the center of secularism discourse
 2. Using gender equality as an argument for secularism → Aims to prove western superiority (not factual)
 3. We are not looking at the right issue and it’s just a shortcut avoiding the real difficulties
- 19th and 20th Centuries:
 1. Promiscuity vs procreation
 2. Private sphere = Feminine WHILE Public = politic = manley
 3. Women in kitchen → not just religious thing but product of discourse of secularism
 4. Wait years for woman to start have the same right (100 years after french and American revolutions) → secularism has never been about woman freedom
 5. When Islam came to western world → THEN woman rights were taken as a part of **“New” Secularism → Sexual liberation**
 - Women are **instrumentalized** → giving rights was not just of pure kindness but because it comforted western society in their supposed superiority over islam
 - **Sexual emancipation != gender equality**
 - It is like **liberal feminism** → Men pose as the savior but actually we just change the exploiter
 - * From being exploited by aytollah for the headscarf → exploited by pimp on onlyfans cause “that’s freedom”
 - * Never a true emancipation → woman is still an object, just flashy rebranding, stays a commodity
 - Foucault: actual emancipation is de-sexualization
 - Sexuality + politics → always an unstable discourse
- How to achieve emancipation ?
 1. Definitions:
 - “Lifting of restraints imposed by superior physical force or legal obligation” (Oxford English Dictionary)
 - Patria potestas (roman law)
 - NOT ABOUT EQUALITY → about freedom
 2. Reification of desire

- Sexuality is singled out
- Motivate actions by desire
- Freedom act upon and fulfill desires (no equality in gender)

6 Class - 7

6.1 Sweet 2007

William Sweet's article uses the debate between Intelligent Design (ID) and evolutionary theory to explore the broader conceptual relationship between scientific propositions and religious beliefs. He argues that a failure to understand the distinct epistemological nature of these two types of claims hinders the resolution of both the ID debate and the larger discourse on science and religion.

The Intelligent Design vs. Evolution Debate

Sweet observes that ID and naturalistic evolution are often treated as competing hypotheses. He contends that critics who dismiss ID simply as a religious belief commit the genetic fallacy; ID should be evaluated on its scientific merits and plausibility, rather than being rejected based on the religious motivations of its proponents. Conversely, he argues that ID advocates are mistaken if they believe that ID, even if scientifically successful, can definitively *prove* religious claims. For instance, a scientific conclusion that biological complexity requires an "intelligent designer" does not prove the distinctively religious belief that this designer is the Creator God worshipped by believers.

The Distinct Nature of Scientific and Religious Beliefs

To clarify how the two realms relate, Sweet contrasts the nature of their propositions:

- **Scientific propositions** describe matters of fact, are publicly testable, and are inherently neutral and objective. Their meaning and truth do not depend on the ethical, metaphysical, or religious values of the person testing or stating them.
- **Religious beliefs** are a response to the world that have expressive roles, indicate a disposition or intention to act in certain ways, and are intimately tied to specific practices, such as prayer and worship. Despite these dispositional elements, religious beliefs still possess a descriptive dimension and can be evaluated for truth based on internal consistency, tradition, and coherence with other known truths.

While distinct, Sweet notes they are not radically separate because both make claims about the same world and share core general criteria for truth.

The Mutual Interaction of Science and Religion

Sweet rejects both "fideism" (which radically separates science and religion) and "strict empiricism" (which tries to reduce religion to science). Instead, he outlines a correlative relationship where both fields must ultimately cohere:

- **How Science Bears on Religion:** Science cannot definitively prove religious beliefs; for example, archaeological proof of the crucifixion of a man named Jesus would not prove the religious belief that he is the Messiah. However, science can *indirectly challenge* religious beliefs by disproving empirical claims those beliefs presuppose. When scientific discoveries conflict with religious assumptions, it forces believers to re-examine what their beliefs actually mean and clarify whether certain claims—like a six-day creation—are meant scientifically or religiously.
- **How Religion Bears on Science:** While religion cannot directly disprove a scientific proposition from within the bounds of science, it can serve as a guide and a judge. Religious beliefs can encourage scientists to pursue

socially responsible research that respects human dignity, or they can challenge scientists when they make broad philosophical assumptions, such as insisting on purely materialistic accounts of human consciousness.

Ultimately, Sweet concludes that because both scientific practice and religious belief must be subordinate to the truth, they bear on one another and their true propositions must eventually “fit together” without one being reduced to the other.

7 Class - 8

7.1 Hansson 2017

Sven Ove Hansson’s 2017 chapter, “Theories and Methods for the Ethics of Technology,” explores the foundational concepts and methodologies used to evaluate ethical issues surrounding technology. He argues that the ethics of technology should not simply be a rigid application of traditional moral theories, but rather a flexible, practical discipline that utilizes a variety of analytical tools.

Defining Technology

Hansson notes that the meaning of “technology” has evolved significantly. In the 19th century, it primarily referred to *knowledge* about the skills and tools of craftsmen, but by the 20th century, it shifted to describe the actual tools, machines, and procedures themselves. Importantly, he emphasizes that technology encompasses not only physical hardware but also the social practices and rules associated with its use; understanding this social embedding is crucial for evaluating its ethical impact.

The Limits of “Applying” Moral Theory

Hansson strongly critiques the notion that applied ethics—including the ethics of technology—is merely the direct application of overarching moral theories (like utilitarianism or deontology) to solve practical problems. He identifies three major problems with this approach:

- **The Theory Choice Problem:** Moral philosophers fundamentally disagree on which moral theory is the “correct” one, making the choice of which theory to apply seem arbitrary.
- **The Derivation Problem:** Broad, abstract moral theories rarely provide specific, clear-cut answers to the nuanced, concrete dilemmas encountered in practical fields.
- **The Moral Novelty Problem:** Emerging technologies continually introduce unprecedented moral dilemmas (e.g., virtual reality, biotechnology, and human enhancement) that older, established moral theories could not have foreseen.

Alternative Methods for the Ethics of Technology

Because strict application of theory is insufficient, Hansson proposes alternative ways to structure ethical investigations:

- **Tempered Use of Moral Theories:** Instead of using moral theories to dictate answers, ethicists should use them to provide precise conceptual tools (like “prima facie rights” or “moral luck”) and rigorous “thought patterns” (like utilitarianism’s weighing of advantages). He also advocates for seeking a **“reflective equilibrium,”** a process of mutually adjusting specific moral judgments and general principles until they align logically.
- **Principlism:** Another alternative is to use area-specific guiding principles, similar to the four pillars of medical ethics (autonomy, non-maleficence, beneficence, and justice). However, Hansson cautions that applying principlism

to technology requires extensive reworking. Unlike clinical medicine, which focuses on an individual patient, technological decisions often impact large, diverse groups with conflicting interests, meaning concepts like individual “informed consent” do not easily translate.

Impartial Analysis vs. Ethical Activism

Finally, Hansson examines the role of the ethicist, distinguishing between impartial scholarly analysis and ethical activism. He outlines four types of ethical statements and argues that an ethicist’s true academic expertise lies in **analytical normative statements**—identifying hidden assumptions, separating normative issues from facts, and clarifying alternative standpoints. While ethicists are free to personally advocate for specific moral choices (activism), Hansson cautions that they should not present this advocacy as scholarly expertise, as doing so can diminish the credibility of their academic work.

7.2 Verbeek 2008

Peter-Paul Verbeek’s 2008 article, “Obstetric Ultrasound and the Technological Mediation of Morality,” argues that technologies are not morally neutral instruments, but active participants that shape human moral subjectivity. By integrating “postphenomenology” with Michel Foucault’s ethical theories, Verbeek demonstrates that technological artifacts profoundly mediate our moral decisions.

Postphenomenology and Technological Mediation

Verbeek builds upon Don Ihde’s “postphenomenological” approach, which breaks away from classical phenomenology’s foundational, anti-science attempt to describe “reality itself”. Instead, postphenomenology argues that human perception and reality are mutually constituted through technological mediation. Technologies do not simply connect pre-existing subjects to pre-existing objects; rather, they help construct what is real to us. Consequently, Verbeek argues that we must abandon the idea of the autonomous human “prime mover” in ethics. Moral agency and intentionality do not reside solely in humans, but are distributed across human-technology associations.

The Moral Mediation of Obstetric Ultrasound

To illustrate how technologies shape moral actions, Verbeek analyzes obstetric ultrasound. Far from being a neutral “window to the womb,” ultrasound acts hermeneutically by actively translating data into a specific representation, fundamentally altering the ontological status of the unborn:

- **The Fetus as a Person:** Ultrasound visually isolates the unborn from the mother’s body, makes it appear larger, and can reveal its gender, thereby constituting the fetus as a separate, individual person or “baby”.
- **The Fetus as a Patient:** By translating the unborn into quantifiable medical variables and disease risks, ultrasound frames pregnancy as a medical process to be monitored.
- **Parents as Decision-Makers:** This technological mediation fundamentally changes the experience of “expecting” a child into “choosing” a child. Even if a couple did not explicitly seek to make a moral choice about abortion, the technology forcefully constitutes the parents as decision-makers responsible for assessing risks and determining the life of the unborn child.

Foucault and Moral Subjectivity

Because technology inevitably shapes who we are and what dilemmas we face, Verbeek turns to the late work of Michel Foucault. Foucault viewed ethics not merely as obedience to a set of moral imperatives, but as the active constitution of one’s own subjectivity. He emphasized “practices of the self”—the explicit styling and shaping of oneself into a moral individual. Verbeek suggests that in our modern era, technology is one of the most powerful determinants of this subject constitution.

A New Ethics of Technology: Technological Ascesis

Verbeek criticizes ethical frameworks that try to separate humanity from technology, such as “precautionary” approaches that aim to pull the emergency brake on technological development. Because humanity and technology are intimately interwoven, Verbeek advocates for a practice of **technological ascesis**.

This does not mean retreating from technology; rather, it means deliberately using technology while reflecting on and actively modifying how it mediates our lives. For example, expecting parents can engage in moral self-practices by consciously choosing *how* they use ultrasound—perhaps by refusing it, using it only to determine the birth date without seeking risk assessments, or explicitly accepting all tests. Ultimately, Verbeek concludes that the ethics of technology should be centered on asking what kind of mediated subjects we want to become, and explicitly shaping our relationship with the technologies that constitute us.

8 Class - 9

8.1 Falhquist 2017

Jessica Nihlén Falhquist’s 2017 chapter, “Responsibility Analysis,” explores the conceptual and normative issues surrounding moral responsibility in the context of technology and engineering. The text primarily investigates whether engineers have a special moral responsibility and how the design of technology affects human responsibility.

Conditions for Moral Responsibility and Blame

Traditionally, moral responsibility is viewed as a backward-looking concept focused on blameworthiness. Falhquist outlines five standard conditions that must be met to hold an agent morally responsible for a negative outcome: **capacity, causality, knowledge, freedom, and wrongdoing**. The process of ascribing blame involves both immediate emotional reactions (such as resentment) and a detached, cognitive reflection of the situation. Ultimately, holding someone responsible serves two main aims: **fairness** (blaming someone for a wrongful act) and **efficacy** (detering people from repeating the act).

Backward-Looking vs. Forward-Looking Responsibility

A central theme in the text is the distinction between two types of responsibility:

- **Backward-looking responsibility** focuses on who caused an undesired event and who is to blame.
- **Forward-looking responsibility** focuses on who should do something to prevent the event from happening again in the future.

Falhquist illustrates this using Sweden’s “Vision Zero” road safety policy, which shifted the focus from the backward-looking responsibility of individual drivers who cause accidents to the forward-looking responsibility of “system designers” (e.g., local governments and car manufacturers) to create infrastructure that prevents fatal collisions.

Individual vs. Collective Responsibility Responsibility can be shared among individuals and collective entities, such as corporations or states, which often creates tension between what is a fair distribution of responsibility and what is an effective one. In large-scale engineering and technological development projects, it is often difficult to identify exactly who caused a negative outcome because so many agents are involved. This dilemma is known as the **“problem of many hands”**.

“Taking” Responsibility: Task vs. Virtue

In addition to distributing responsibility, Falhquist explores the forward-looking concept of an individual actively “taking responsibility,” which is conceptualized in two ways:

- **Responsibility as a Task:** Unlike basic duties that dictate specific actions, responsibilities dictate *results*. For example, engineers are often expected to “see to it” that a safe product is achieved, requiring them to evaluate actions and formulate a plan to reach that result.
- **Responsibility as a Virtue:** This is a cultivated character trait where a person proactively takes on more responsibilities than their specific tasks dictate. In engineering, this virtue requires moral imagination and empathy to consider how technological failures might impact real people.

How Technology Affects Responsibility

Fahlquist argues that **technological design actively alters how responsibility is distributed and how willing users are to take responsibility**. Behavior-steering technologies can shift or even hamper a user’s disposition to act responsibly:

- **Alcohol Interlocks:** Devices that prevent a car from starting if the driver has consumed alcohol force sobriety but remove individual responsibility for the choice to drive sober. This might inadvertently cause users to view the device as a catch-all test for fitness to drive, leading them to ignore other risks like fatigue.
- **GPS Tracking for Children:** While parents use GPS to protect their children, over-relying on this technology signals to children that someone else is always in control. This lack of independent experience can hamper a child’s ability to develop the virtue of responsibility as they grow.

Ultimately, Fahlquist concludes that engineers hold a moral responsibility that extends beyond their basic job descriptions, and they must carefully reflect on how their designs impact the behaviors and moral development of users.

8.2 Technology and responsibility

Hans Jonas’s 1973 article, “Technology and Responsibility: Reflections on the New Tasks of Ethics,” argues that the unprecedented scale and power of modern technology have fundamentally altered the nature of human action, thereby rendering traditional ethical frameworks insufficient. He calls for a radically new ethics oriented toward the long-term survival of humanity and the preservation of the natural world.

The Limits of Traditional Ethics

Historically, human interaction with the non-human world (*techne*) was considered ethically neutral. Using the chorus from Sophocles’ *Antigone* as an example, Jonas illustrates that ancient humans viewed nature as an inexhaustible, immutable force. Because human incursions into nature were superficial and localized, traditional ethics was strictly **anthropocentric**, focusing entirely on direct interactions between humans in the “here and now”. Ethical knowledge did not require scientific expertise; it was rooted in common sense and applied to immediate consequences.

The Vulnerability of Nature

Modern technology has shattered this paradigm. The biosphere is no longer immune to human action; it is profoundly vulnerable. Because technological interventions are global, cumulative, and irreversible, nature itself has become an object of human responsibility. Jonas suggests we must move beyond anthropocentrism and consider whether the extra-human world has a moral claim on us in its own right. Furthermore, because our actions have such sprawling, long-term effects, acquiring predictive knowledge is now a moral duty.

A New Moral Imperative

Because traditional ethics, like Kant’s categorical imperative, evaluates actions based on immediate, logical consistency for the individual, it cannot account for the distant future. Jonas proposes a new imperative tailored to the age of technology: **“Act so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life”**. For the first time in history, the continued existence of humanity has become an object of moral obligation.

Technology Modifying Humanity

Jonas notes that the most ominous shift is that *homo faber* (man the maker) is now turning his technological power upon himself. He highlights three areas where technology threatens the human condition:

- **Life Extension:** Advancements in biology might allow us to significantly delay or conquer death. However, immortality would require halting procreation to prevent overpopulation, leaving a stagnant world of old age devoid of the spontaneity and fresh perspectives of youth.
- **Behavior Control:** Using chemical or electronic means (like brain implants) to pacify behavior or artificially induce happiness strips individuals of their autonomy. Bypassing the normal human ways of dealing with problems reduces people to programmed behavior systems, threatening human dignity.
- **Genetic Control:** Taking evolution into our own hands through genetic design forces us to ask whether we possess the wisdom, the standards, or the right to design future human beings.

The Need for Humility and Representation

Modern technology operates on a “utopian” scale, pushing us toward extreme goals that impact the total condition of the globe. This creates a paradox: we require supreme wisdom to manage these powers, yet the same scientific movement that gave us this technology has eroded our belief in objective truths and norms, leaving us in a state of “nihilism”.

Because our power to act vastly outstrips our ability to foresee consequences, Jonas calls for a **new kind of humility** based on recognizing our ignorance. Furthermore, he notes a severe political challenge: representative governments are unsuited for this task because future generations—the ones who will suffer the consequences of our technological choices—have no lobby or political power today. Ultimately, Jonas concludes that since religion can no longer universally anchor morality, we must use reason to urgently build an ethics capable of guiding our awesome technological power before we default to a disastrous one.

9 Class - 10

9.1 Moula 2017

Payam Moula and Per Sandin’s 2017 chapter, “Ethical Tools,” explores the definition, application, and evaluation of practical methods designed to improve ethical deliberations, specifically within the context of technology assessment.

What are Ethical Tools?

Ethical tools are practical methods or conceptual frameworks—such as checklists, codes of conduct, or flowcharts—that help users (often non-philosophers) reach ethically informed judgments. Most ethical tools function by ensuring that users consider the right aspects in the correct sequence, focusing primarily on the **inclusion, order, and occasionally the weighing** of relevant moral considerations.

Examples of Ethical Tools in Technology Assessment

The authors outline several specific tools used to assess new technologies, which range from individual frameworks to large-scale meeting formats:

- **The Ethical Matrix:** Developed by Ben Mepham, this tool creates a grid that cross-references broad ethical principles (such as well-being, autonomy, and justice) with various stakeholders affected by a technology. While it is praised for being simple and helping users identify relevant considerations, it has been criticized for **failing to help users weigh conflicting values to actually reach a decision**. It also risks reproducing the biases of the facilitators if key stakeholders are initially left out of the matrix.

- **The Ethical Delphi:** A virtual, anonymous committee format used to elicit **expert opinions** over several rounds of written exchange. It highlights both consensus and disagreement while preventing dominant personalities from taking over, though it has been criticized for lacking public transparency.
- **The Consensus Conference:** A multi-day event focused on **public participation**, where a panel of laypeople learns about a controversial topic from experts and deliberates to reach a consensus. While valuable for democracy, it can suffer from low or self-selected attendance, and genuine consensus might be masked by minority views staying quiet.
- **Convergence Seminars:** A shorter, few-hours-long format that evaluates emerging tech using **hypothetical retrospection**. Participants are divided into groups to discuss concrete future scenarios, evaluating choices based on the idea of avoiding future regret.

Evaluating Ethical Tools

The authors note that despite the wide variety of ethical tools available, there is surprisingly little literature on how to determine what makes a tool “good”. They review several approaches:

- *Stability:* Ellen-Marie Forsberg suggested tools should have intermethodological stability (different users reaching the same conclusion). However, Moula and Sandin argue that if a tool guarantees the same result regardless of the user, it is likely biased; **a good tool should still leave room for the user’s specific values and judgment.**
- *Ethical Soundness:* Kaiser et al. proposed a binary framework where tools are either ethically “sound” or “unsound” based on factors like transparency and inclusion of values. The authors argue this is too rigid, as tools exist on a spectrum of quality.
- **Purposiveness:** Moula and Sandin propose evaluating tools based on their “purposiveness”—**how well they achieve their specifically designed aims.** Universal metrics should include comprehensiveness and user-friendliness, while context-specific metrics might include transparency (if public scrutiny is expected) or procedural fairness (for public engagement tools).

Future Challenges

The authors conclude with future challenges for ethical tools. They suggest that the rise of “ethics apps” and autonomous technological systems might alter or even diminish the traditional role of professional ethicists. Furthermore, they highlight a major limitation of most ethical tools: they generally only work if the users belong to the same **moral community**, meaning they must share a significant baseline of ethical values to deliberate effectively.

10 AI summary of classes

10.1 Defining Religion

Class 2 of the “Religions” course focuses on the complexities of **defining religion**. Drawing heavily from the mandatory readings by Jeppe Sinding Jensen and Craig Martin, the lecture emphasizes that “religion” is not a naturally occurring, objective fact, but rather an analytic term and a theory-dependent concept—it is a “map” of human behavior rather than the “territory” itself.

The Politics of Definition

The lecture and readings highlight that how we define religion depends on who is asking, when they are asking, and what their interests are. Craig Martin argues that definitions are often shaped by political and social agendas, much like how the legal definition of “wetlands” fluctuates depending on whether conservationists or land developers are writing the rules. For example, the definition of yoga shifts depending on context: practitioners might argue it is “spiritual” but not “religious” to avoid violating the separation of church and state in public schools, while state governments might argue it is secular to justify taxing yoga studios.

Historical Context: It Depends on When!

The lecture stresses that the modern understanding of “religion” as a private matter separated from politics is a relatively recent invention:

- **Pre-Modernity:** Prior to the Protestant Reformation, there was no concept of religion as a distinct cultural tradition separated from other social spheres. The ancient Latin term *religio* referred to devotion, reverence, and the meticulous observation of rules, rather than a private belief system.
- **Early Modernity:** The modern separation of Church and State emerged during the violence of the Protestant Reformation. Thinkers like John Locke argued for distinct boundaries between the commonwealth and the church to promote tolerance, creating a “useful fiction” that relegated religion to the private sphere.

Colonialism and the Christian Ideal

The lecture warns that defining “religion” carries significant normative baggage and has historically been used as a tool for European colonialism. European scholars traditionally set up **Christianity as the universal standard or “ideal type”** for what constitutes a religion. Other cultural traditions were judged based on whether they had a founder (like Jesus), central doctrines, sacred texts, rituals, and communal buildings (like a church).

This framework justified imperialist agendas by labeling non-Western traditions as “primitive,” “savage,” or “irrational” compared to advanced European religions. Furthermore, relying on this Christian model has historically disadvantaged groups like Native Americans in modern religious freedom legal cases, as their practices did not fit the traditional European mold of what a “religion” should look like.

Five Intellectual “Turns” in Studying Religion

Because defining religion depends heavily on the scholar’s perspective, the lecture outlines five major intellectual “turns” in the academic study of religion:

1. **The Functional Turn (Émile Durkheim):** Defines religion socially as a unified system of beliefs and practices that unite adherents into a single moral community or Church.
2. **The Psychoanalytic Turn (Sigmund Freud):** Views religion critically as a “universal obsessional neurosis of humanity,” rooted in illusions and psychological complexes.

3. **The Existentialist Turn (Paul Tillich):** Defines religion functionally as a state of being grasped by an “ultimate concern” that addresses the meaning of life and helps humans cope existentially.
4. **The Linguistic/Cultural Turn (Clifford Geertz):** Sees religion as a cultural system of symbols that establishes powerful moods and motivations by formulating conceptions of a general order of existence.
5. **The Cognitive Turn (Pascal Boyer):** Understands religion from an evolutionary perspective as a by-product (or “spandrel”) of normal human cognitive operations and biology.

A Tentative Definition

Ultimately, the lecture asks if we can find a lowest common denominator for everything we colloquially call a religion, from Christianity to indigenous practices, or even to phenomena like Marxism and American nationalism. Because strict definitions fail to encompass all these disparate groups, the class proposes viewing religion as a **“family resemblance” concept** (drawing on the philosopher Ludwig Wittgenstein). This means religions share a network of overlapping traits without needing a single universal feature.

The lecture concludes with a tentative, practical definition provided by Jensen: religion consists of “semantic and cognitive networks comprising ideas, behaviours and institutions in relation to counter-intuitive superhuman agents, objects and posits”.

10.2 Secularism

Class 3 of the “Religions” course delves into the concept of **secularization** and the extensive academic debate surrounding the idea that the world is becoming increasingly secular and less religious.

Defining the Terms

The lecture begins by distinguishing between closely related terms:

- **Secular:** Pertaining to the worldly or civil affairs, as opposed to the ecclesiastical or sacred.
- **Secularization:** The process—typically taking place in the public arena—whereby ecclesiastical institutions, properties, or directions of study are converted to secular use or character.
- **Secularism:** A doctrine or private view that morality and education should be based solely on human well-being in the present life, excluding considerations of God or the afterlife.

Foundational Sociological Views

The lecture contrasts two foundational perspectives stemming from the Enlightenment’s emphasis on rationality:

- **Max Weber** viewed secularization as an unavoidable process of “disenchantment” driven by societal rationalization. He believed Protestantism planted the seeds for this by encouraging rational organization, ultimately leading to a world where religion loses its unquestioned public authority.
- **Émile Durkheim** had a more optimistic view, arguing that the decline of religion is only apparent. Because religion provides essential social cohesion and solidarity, he believed that while old gods might die, society will inevitably create “new ideals” and formulas to guide humanity.

The Secularization Thesis and Its Critics

The core of the class focuses on the “secularization debate,” spearheaded by **Bryan R. Wilson**. Wilson defined secularization as the process whereby “religious thinking, practice and institutions lose social significance”. He argued that increased rationality and cause-and-effect thinking have marginalized religion. He even dismissed high church attendance in the United States as a “superficial” social identity rather than true religious depth.

Wilson’s classic thesis faced several major responses and critiques:

- **David Martin:** Argued the thesis is an ideological tool based on the false premise of a historical “Golden Age” of religion that never actually existed. He also noted that modern society remains full of superstition.
- **Andrew Greeley:** Countered that declining church membership statistics do not necessarily mean a decline in personal religiosity, and argued that America is not becoming increasingly secular.
- **Rodney Stark, William Bainbridge, & Laurence Iannaccone:** Proposed a “religious economies” or supply-side model. They argued that science cannot solve existential human problems, so the demand for religion is constant. They view religious change as cyclic. Furthermore, they argued that a “free market” with competing religious organizations (like in the US) generates religious enthusiasm, whereas state monopolies on religion breed complacency and lack of interest.

Secularization and Confusion

The lecture concludes by highlighting the chaotic nature of the debate. Drawing on the mandatory reading by **Sharon Hanson**, the class notes that scholars are often “talking at cross-purposes” because they use entirely different definitions of “religion” and “secularization”. Furthermore, Hanson criticizes the debate for its uncritical use of historical data and its heavy “Christo-centric” bias.

Ultimately, the rise of religious pluralism, diversity, and new religious movements forces modern scholars, like Peter Berger, to question whether true secularization is actually taking place or if religion is simply transforming.

10.3 Guest Lecture: Pacifism

The Reality of Evil and the Appeal of Pacifism

The lecture begins by noting that modern society often ignores evil until it becomes a direct threat, while postmodernism tends to dismiss moral guilt and responsibility altogether. In response to the existential threat of nuclear weapons in the 20th century, **pacifism** saw a massive resurgence, championed by figures like Mahatma Gandhi, Martin Luther King Jr., and Thomas Merton. During the Second Vatican Council, the Catholic Church officially recognized non-violent resistance and pacifism as a valid personal moral choice alongside Just War theory, affirming that the state no longer entirely dictates an individual’s moral choices regarding war.

The Biblical and Practical Limits of Pacifism

Despite its moral appeal, the lecture outlines severe limitations to strict pacifism:

- **Biblical context:** Jesus’s command to “turn the other cheek” refers to enduring personal insults rather than accepting physical violence. Furthermore, Jesus used force to cleanse the Temple, and the New Testament explicitly praises the faith of soldiers without demanding they leave the military.
- **Person vs. State:** There is a vital distinction between the individual and the government. While an individual is called to forgive personal offenses, **the state is authorized by God to protect the innocent, preserve peace, and punish wrongdoers**, utilizing the “sword” if necessary.
- **Practical failures:** Pacifist tactics cannot succeed under totalitarian regimes like modern Russia or North Korea. Historically, pacifism has inadvertently aided tyrants, whereas military force was necessary to defeat evils like Nazism, fascism, and slavery.

Just War Theory and Lawful Self-Defense

Originating with early Church fathers like St. Augustine and St. Ambrose, **Just War Theory** was developed to ensure self-defense does not escalate into unbridled violence. For a war to be considered just, it must meet seven strict criteria:

1. **Just Cause:** Unprovoked aggression is condemned, but self-defense is a moral and legal right.

2. **Just Intent:** The sole goal must be securing a just peace, not revenge, conquest, or economic gain.
3. **Lawful Declaration:** Only legitimate governments, not private individuals, can declare war.
4. **Last Resort:** All peaceful paths like negotiation and compromise must be exhausted first.
5. **Immunity of Noncombatants:** Civilians and medical personnel must never be targeted.
6. **Limited Objectives:** The aim is peace, not the total destruction of the enemy nation.
7. **Proportionate Means:** Force must be limited to exactly what is required to repel the aggression.

Ultimately, the lecture argues that applying just war principles to protect the vulnerable from tyrants is an act of **love for one's neighbor**.

Application to Russia's War in Ukraine

The lecture categorizes Russia's invasion of Ukraine as an act of **unprovoked aggression aimed at entirely destroying Ukrainian statehood and identity**. This aggression is driven by multiple unjust motives:

- **Geopolitical:** Seeking dominance over former USSR territories and blocking Ukraine's integration with the West.
- **Ideological:** Denying Ukraine's right to exist and attempting to erase its culture and language.
- **Economic & Strategic:** Seizing industrial resources, establishing a land corridor to Crimea, and dominating the Black Sea.

A New Paradigm: Just Peacemaking Theory

Recognizing that neither pacifism nor just war theory is entirely sufficient on its own, the lecture concludes by introducing **Just Peacemaking Theory**, a framework developed by US church bodies in the 1980s. This paradigm focuses on proactive practices to prevent war, centered around ten core initiatives. These include **supporting nonviolent direct action, advancing human rights and democracy, fostering sustainable economic development, and strengthening international cooperation** to build a just and lasting peace.

10.4 Guest Lecture: Reconciliation

This lecture outlines the theological foundations, guiding principles, and practical applications of **reconciliation**, framing it as an ongoing process necessary to rebuild society's moral order.

Here is a comprehensive summary of the lecture's core themes:

The Foundations and Principles of Reconciliation

Fundamentally, reconciliation is defined as the restoration of friendly relations and the process of making conflicting views compatible. In theology, **reconciliation is viewed as a work and gift of God**, though humans are actively invited to be "peacemakers" and co-workers in this ministry.

The primary goal of reconciliation cannot be reduced solely to the individual level; it aims at the **ongoing reconstruction of the moral order of society**. Achieving this requires moving from a divided memory toward shared experiences, utilizing cross-border cooperation, joint education, and symbolic actions. It also requires addressing multiple levels of justice, specifically **restitutional justice** (redressing specific injustices, such as victim funds) and **structural justice** (fixing the root causes of conflict, such as land reform). Real-world examples of this work include the Truth and Reconciliation Commissions in South Africa and Chile, as well as peace efforts in Northern Ireland and Israel-Palestine.

Key Perspectives from Leading Thinkers

The lecture highlights four major figures to conceptualize how reconciliation is achieved:

- **Miroslav Volf on “Remembering Rightly”:** Volf emphasizes that memory is ambivalent; while it honors victims, it can also awaken hatred and a desire for revenge. If unchecked, victims can use their traumatic memories to justify becoming perpetrators of new violence. Therefore, **memory must serve reconciliation**. The goal of true memory is not to rigidly fixate on past injustices, but to seek the repentance, transformation, and forgiveness of the offender, allowing victims to let go of the past without denying the truth.
- **Pope Francis on Social Friendship:** Drawing from his encyclical *Fratelli tutti*, Pope Francis stresses the importance of finding a “spark of new hope” in others, acknowledging their potential and legitimate viewpoints rather than defining them solely by their past wrongdoings. He argues that **inequality and a lack of human development make peace impossible**. Importantly, he clarifies that **forgiveness does not mean tolerating oppression**; victims must strenuously defend their rights and God-given dignity against criminals.
- **Robert Schreiter on Freedom and Transformation:** Schreiter views reconciliation as a transformative experience that changes both parties, rather than just returning them to their original state. For the victim, the aim is the restoration of human dignity, and **forgiveness is an expression of freedom**—a conscious choice not to be controlled by the past. He notes that “in forgiving we do not forget; we remember in a different way,” a process that ideally culminates in wishing the other well.
- **Daniel Philpott on Restorative Justice:** Philpott frames reconciliation as a **restorative form of justice** that is meant to rebuild the political community. Rather than focusing purely on retributive punishment, this framework requires the acknowledgment of wrongdoing, truth-telling, reparations, apologies, institutional reform, and the reintegration of offenders.

Conclusions

The lecture concludes by firmly stating what reconciliation is *not*: **it is not forgetfulness, it is not weakness, and it is not a tolerance of evil**. Instead, it is a complex structural, legal, political, and moral process that positions the victim as an active subject. True reconciliation requires the end of the conflict, a period of conscience examination, and the combination of penance and forgiveness to create lasting peace. Ultimately, as Pope St. John Paul II stated, it stands as a claim against the “lie” and evil of violence.

10.5 Secularism

Class 5 of the “Religions” course explores the concept of **secularism**, contrasting its historical applications in France and the United States, and analyzing the concept through the theoretical frameworks of Charles Taylor, Elizabeth Shakman Hurd, and José Casanova.

Defining Secularism: France vs. the United States

At a baseline, secularism is a worldview advocating for the separation of religious and state institutions, guaranteeing freedom of thought and religion, and ensuring equal treatment regardless of religious views. However, the lecture contrasts two vastly different historical models:

- **France (*laïcité*):** French secularism emerged historically from an atheistic campaign of de-Christianization. Solidified by the 1905 law on the separation of church and state, the state abolished compulsory prayers in parliament, removed religious symbols from public buildings, and fully secularized health and education services.
- **United States:** Grounded in the First Amendment’s “no establishment” and “free exercise” clauses, US secularism was designed primarily as a mechanism to guarantee religious freedom rather than an ideological fight against religion itself.

Varieties of Secularisms

Drawing on assigned literature, the lecture emphasizes that secularism is not a single, monolithic concept:

- **Elizabeth Shakman Hurd** contrasts *laicism* (where religion is viewed as an adversary to modernity that must be exiled from politics, as seen in France and China) with *Judeo-Christian secularism* (where religion acts as the moral guarantor of a secular society, as seen in the US).
- **José Casanova** distinguishes secularism as a practical “statecraft principle” from secularism as an “ideology.” As an ideology, secularism negatively assumes religion is irrational or merely a primitive stage of history to be superseded.
- **Charles Taylor** identifies historical “Common Ground” and “Independent” approaches to secularism, ultimately advocating for an “Overlapping Consensus.” In this approach, a diverse society converges on shared political principles, but citizens agree to them for entirely different foundational or religious reasons.

The European vs. American Paradox

Casanova highlights a fascinating sociological discrepancy: Americans and Europeans both lie to pollsters about their faith, but in opposite directions. Americans tend to exaggerate their religious attendance because they equate being modern and American with being legitimately religious. Conversely, Europeans (such as Spaniards) drastically under-report their religiosity. This is because European secularist ideology widely assumes that to be modern, autonomous, and rational means one must emancipate oneself from religion.

Despite this strong secular self-image, Casanova points out that European states are far from strictly neutral. Outside of France’s strict *laïcité*, most European countries maintain highly “unsecular entanglements,” such as established state churches (e.g., in the UK and Nordic countries) or heavy state funding for private Catholic schools (even in France).

Charles Taylor’s *A Secular Age*

The lecture concludes by examining Charles Taylor’s question of how it became possible for modern people to experience “moral fullness” and inspiration using purely human powers, without reference to God. Taylor rejects “subtraction theories”—the idea that modern science simply stripped away religious superstition to reveal a natural, secular foundation.

Instead, he defines the current era (“Secularity 3”) as a time where belief and unbelief uneasily coexist, marking a continuous destabilization and “recomposition” of religious forms rather than their complete disappearance. Ultimately, Taylor suggests that the secular age is imbued with a sense of “malaise” and emptiness, arguing that purely human values are inadequate to provide a true sense of fulfillment without some connection to transcendence.

10.6 Freedom of Speech

Class 6 of the “Religions” course centers on the highly politicized **headscarf debate in France**, using this controversy to explore broader questions about freedom of speech, secularism, and gender equality. The lecture heavily relies on the work of historian Joan Wallach Scott, specifically her books *The Politics of the Veil* and *Sex and Secularism*.

The Timeline of the French Headscarf Controversies

The lecture outlines how the French state’s approach to the Islamic headscarf (and later the burqa) hardened from tolerance to strict prohibition over a few decades:

- **1989 (Creil):** Three Muslim girls were expelled from a middle school for refusing to remove their headscarves. Initially, the French Council of State ruled that wearing religious signs was not incompatible with *laïcité* (French secularism) as long as it did not constitute pressure, provocation, or proselytism, leaving decisions up to individual schools.

- **1994:** François Bayrou, the minister of education, decreed that “ostentatious” signs of religious affiliation were strictly prohibited because they were deemed inherently proselytizing. This led to the expulsion of 69 girls, though courts often overturned these expulsions.
- **2003–2004:** The controversy peaked when two sisters, Alma and Lila Lévy, were expelled. Following recommendations from the Stasi Commission, the French government passed a law in March 2004 banning all “conspicuous” religious symbols in public schools.
- **2009:** President Nicolas Sarkozy declared that the burqa would not be tolerated in France, framing it not as a religious issue, but as an intolerable enslavement and a violation of women’s dignity.

Scott argues that the timing of these laws was not a reaction to an objective increase in headscarf-wearing students. Instead, it was driven by domestic political anxieties: an increase in immigration, fears of terrorism, and the rising popularity of Jean-Marie Le Pen’s far-right National Front party. Mainstream politicians used the headscarf ban to co-opt the far-right’s anti-immigrant messaging and project an image of a unified, secular France.

The Underlying Clash: Sexuality and Gender Systems

While politicians often framed the debate around “security” or a defense against Islamic fundamentalism, the lecture emphasizes that the core of the controversy is actually about **sexuality and a clash of gender systems**.

For French republicans, the veil was deeply disturbing because it represented a fundamentally different way of managing relations between the sexes. The lecture contrasts two frameworks:

- **The French “Open” System:** France celebrates a sexualized public sphere characterized by *mixité* (the mixing of the sexes). In this system, feminine identity is heavily tied to visual stimulation, male desire, and the accessibility of the female body. To French observers, the veil was seen as an aggressive denial of this system—it was an “aggression” because it deprived men of their assumed right to look at and desire women.
- **The Islamic “Covered” System:** In contrast, Islamic modesty rules view sexuality as a potentially disruptive force to social order that must be managed and kept private. Scott describes this as a “**psychology of recognition**”—it explicitly recognizes the volatile power of sexual differences. Conversely, French republicanism operates on a “**psychology of denial**”; it relies on “abstract individualism” to claim all citizens are perfectly equal, actively suppressing the uncomfortable reality that natural sexual differences complicate this perfect equality.

Deconstructing “Sex and Secularism”

In the final part of the lecture, Scott’s book *Sex and Secularism* is used to deconstruct the modern Western assumption that secularism intrinsically guarantees gender equality, while Islam is synonymous with patriarchal oppression.

Scott makes a threefold argument:

1. **A False History:** Gender equality has *not* always been a core feature of secularism. In fact, 19th-century European secularism heavily relied on gender *inequality*. It created a modern division where the public, rational, and political spheres were strictly male, while women were confined to the private, familial, and religious spheres.
2. **A Tool of Supremacy:** The sudden, late-20th-century association of secularism with gender equality (“New Secularism”) emerged primarily as a way to prove the cultural superiority of the Christian West over Islam.
3. **Conflating Emancipation with Equality:** The West often confuses “sexual emancipation” with true gender equality. Emancipation historically means the lifting of restraints or a freedom to act on consumerist and sexual desires. Today, the West points to the visible, uncovered, and sexually available female body as proof of liberation. However, Scott argues that this merely replaces religious constraints with the demands of the capitalist market, where women are encouraged to present themselves as commodities.

Ultimately, the lecture argues that banning the headscarf in the name of “freedom” actually distracts from the persistent gender inequalities (like wage gaps and domestic violence) that still heavily plague Western, secular societies.

10.7 Religion and Science

Class 7 of the “Religions” course examines the complex relationship between **Religion and Science**. The lecture first traces the historical shifts in this debate before using the work of philosopher William Sweet to conceptually analyze how scientific hypotheses and religious beliefs interact, using the Evolution versus Intelligent Design (ID) debate as a primary case study.

Historical Context and Three Models of Interaction

The lecture outlines three historical phases in the science vs. religion debate:

- **Phase I (15th-16th century):** Centered on astronomy (Copernicus and Galileo), taking place largely within a religious sphere.
- **Phase II (18th-19th century):** Centered on biology (Evolution vs. Creationism), taking place in the public and legal spheres.
- **Phase III (20th-21st century):** Centered on cosmology, biology, and epistemology, taking place largely within scientific discourse.

Historically, scholars propose three ways to view the relationship between science and religion:

1. **Conflict:** Either science opposes religion (demonstrating the falsity of religious beliefs) or religion opposes science (restricting autonomous scientific research).
2. **Fundamentally Compatible:** Seen historically through the Islamic support of mathematics/astronomy (9th-15th century) or the Catholic Church funding Renaissance science, implying that God’s creation is rational, ordered, and open to investigation.
3. **Independent/Non-Overlapping:** Thinkers like Stephen Jay Gould argue they are “non-overlapping magisteria.” As Galileo noted, religion tells us how to go to heaven, not how the heavens go. Conflict only occurs when one oversteps its boundaries into the other’s realm.

William Sweet’s Conceptual Analysis: Evolution vs. Intelligent Design

To better understand how science and religion relate today, the lecture heavily draws on William Sweet’s four-step analysis of the Intelligent Design (ID) debate.

While evolutionary accounts argue that biological development is an undirected, reactive process, proponents of ID argue that intelligent causes for complex biology are necessary and empirically detectable. Sweet clarifies this debate by deconstructing the terms involved:

- **Theory vs. Hypothesis:** Critics often dismiss ID as unscientific. Sweet notes that while ID may not be a fully elaborated, predictive scientific *theory*, it can still function as a scientific *hypothesis* (a conditional explanation capable of being tested).
- **The Genetic Fallacy:** ID is often attacked simply because religious people champion it. Sweet argues this is a genetic fallacy: even if ID aligns with religious ideas, ID itself is a hypothesis about nature, not a religious belief.

Defining Religious Beliefs vs. Scientific Hypotheses

Sweet argues that to understand their relationship, we must define how religious and scientific propositions differ, while recognizing they are not completely separate:

- **Scientific Hypotheses:** These are neutral, publicly testable propositions designed to describe matters of fact or how those facts exist, independent of the personal values of the scientist.
- **Religious Beliefs:** These are not just about “another world” but are responses to this world. They are highly personal, expressing a function in a person’s life and indicating a disposition to act in a certain way. However, they

also have a *descriptive* element—they make truth claims about reality that must be logically consistent and cohere with other known facts.

- **The Overlap:** Because both science and religion operate in the same world, respond to experiences in the world, and commend humans to act in certain ways, they are distinct but **not radically distinct**.

The Mutual Relationship: A Two-Way Street

Ultimately, the lecture concludes that the relationship between science and religion is interactive and two-sided. Sweet rejects both fideism (which radically separates the two) and strict empiricism (which reduces religion to science).

1. **How Science Bears on Religion:** Science cannot *prove* a religious belief. However, because religious beliefs make descriptive claims about the world, science can indirectly challenge them. For example, if science proved a historical figure never existed, it would force believers to reassess or abandon the religious beliefs tied to that figure. Science forces religion to ensure its beliefs “fit” with empirical reality.
2. **How Religion Bears on Science:** Religion cannot directly disprove a scientific proposition. However, religion can serve as a vital moral guide for science, directing researchers toward socially responsible fields that preserve human dignity. Furthermore, religion can challenge the philosophical or ideological assumptions that sometimes masquerade as pure science (such as the assumption that the mind is merely a material byproduct).

10.8 Ethics of Technology

Class 8 of the “Religions” course transitions into the realm of **Ethics and the Ethics of Technology**. Drawing heavily from the readings by Sven Ove Hansson and Peter-Paul Verbeek, the lecture explores how we define technology, how we approach applied ethics, and how technologies actively mediate our moral decisions.

Defining Technology and Ethics

The lecture begins by establishing that “technology” refers not only to material objects like tools, machines, and computers, but also encompasses the **social practices**, skills, and rules associated with these objects. When evaluating technology ethically, the academic discourse typically shifts from foundational moral philosophy (searching for comprehensive basic principles) to applied ethics, where professional and area-specific practical issues are addressed.

From Phenomenology to Post-phenomenology

The core theoretical framework of the lecture relies on a shift from traditional phenomenology to post-phenomenology:

- **Phenomenology:** Traditionally analyzes how human beings direct their attention toward a world of objects (intentionality). This framework assumes an active, autonomous human subject acting upon a passive, mute object.
- **Post-phenomenology:** Building on the work of Don Ihde, this approach rejects the strict separation of subject and object, arguing instead that they mutually constitute each other through **technological mediation**. In our modern world, human perceptions, interpretations, and moral decisions are almost always mediated by technologies. Therefore, moral agency is not solely a human affair; it is distributed across both humans and technological artifacts.

Case Study: A Post-phenomenology of Obstetric Ultrasound

To demonstrate how technology mediates morality, the lecture uses Verbeek’s analysis of the obstetric ultrasound. While often viewed simply as a neutral, non-invasive technology that makes the unborn visible, a post-phenomenological lens reveals that it is highly “invasive” in a moral sense because it actively constitutes the unborn and the parents in specific ways:

- **The Fetus as a Person:** The ultrasound visually isolates the fetus from the mother's body, presenting it floating freely. Even an 11-week-old fetus (which is only 8.5 cm) appears on screen to have the size and characteristics of a newborn baby, contributing to a sense of "fetal personhood".
- **The Fetus as a Patient:** The ultrasound translates pregnancy into a highly medicalized process of risk assessment and monitoring. This fundamentally shifts the experience from "expecting a child" to "choosing a child," as parents must decide whether to undergo further testing or terminate the pregnancy if defects are found.
- **Shifting Relationships:** The mother loses her exclusive, "special relationship" with the unborn, often being reframed as the "environment" the fetus lives in, which can lead to surveillance of her lifestyle. Conversely, the father often gains an enhanced relationship via visual contact. Ultimately, the technology thrusts the parents into the difficult role of active decision-makers regarding the life of the unborn.

Foucault: Technology and Moral Subjectivity

Because technologies actively shape our moral decisions (as seen with the ultrasound), the lecture rejects simple instrumentalism (the idea that tech is just a neutral tool) and precautionary approaches (which just try to avoid tech as a threat).

Instead, the lecture draws on **Michel Foucault's concept of ethics as moral self-constitution**. Foucault argued that ethics is not primarily about following a set of rules, but about how human beings actively shape themselves as "subjects" of a moral code. Applying Foucault's four aspects of moral self-constitution to technology, the lecture outlines how we should approach the ethics of technology:

1. **The Ethical Substance:** The "material" of our ethical work is the human subject itself, which takes shape in a complex interplay with mediating technologies.
2. **The Mode of Subjection:** Technological artifacts themselves invite us to recognize specific moral obligations and shape what we even perceive as a moral issue (e.g., the ultrasound forcing the choice to test for Down's syndrome).
3. **Self Practices (Ascesis):** Rather than blindly following or completely rejecting technology, we must practice *ascesis*—taking a deliberate step back to explicitly reflect on how technologies impact our lives, and choosing to use them in a responsible, stylized way.
4. **Teleology:** We must constantly ask ourselves what kind of beings we aspire to be as our human domain interacts with the technological domain.

Ultimately, the class concludes that we cannot separate morality from technology; ethics must actively address how technologies help constitute us as moral subjects.

10.9 Approaches to Ethics of Technology

Class 9 of the "Religions" course focuses on **Approaches to the Ethics of Technology**, specifically unpacking the complex concept of "responsibility." The lecture draws primarily from two key readings: Jessica N. Fahlquist's "Responsibility Analysis" and Hans Jonas's "Technology and Responsibility."

Deconstructing Responsibility

The concept of responsibility in a moral context emerged relatively recently (around the 15th-17th centuries) and fundamentally refers to the capacity to be held accountable, encompassing both negative (blameworthiness) and positive (praiseworthiness) forms. The prototype for all responsibility is parental care, as responsibility intrinsically correlates with power.

For an agent to be held morally blameworthy, five distinct conditions must generally be met:

1. **Capacity:** The person must be a moral agent capable of rational thinking.
2. **Causality:** The agent must be causally linked to the action or consequence.
3. **Knowledge:** The agent must have known what they were doing.
4. **Freedom:** The agent must have acted freely, without being forced.
5. **Wrongdoing:** The action must inherently involve some kind of moral wrong.

Backward-Looking vs. Forward-Looking Responsibility

Drawing on Fahlquist, the lecture emphasizes a crucial distinction between two temporal directions of responsibility:

- **Backward-Looking Responsibility:** This is retrospective. It asks, “Who caused the situation?” and “Who is to blame?”. It is primarily concerned with **fairness**.
- **Forward-Looking Responsibility:** This is prospective. It asks, “Who should do something to prevent this from happening again?”. It is primarily concerned with **efficacy** (solving the problem).

Forward-looking responsibility can be further understood in two ways: as a **task** (an obligation or duty to see that a specific result is achieved) or as a **virtue** (a cultivated character trait or disposition to care for others beyond one’s strict job description). Fahlquist points out that technologies themselves can mediate how much responsibility we take; for instance, alcohol interlocks in cars or GPS trackers on children can actively steer behavior and potentially alter a user’s disposition to take personal responsibility.

The Problem of Many Hands

In modern technological development, innovation takes place in large, collective projects. This creates the “**problem of many hands**”: when a negative outcome occurs (like an oil spill or a space shuttle disaster), it is incredibly difficult to identify a single causally responsible individual to blame, even though the collective entity is morally responsible.

Hans Jonas and the Obsolescence of Traditional Ethics

The second half of the lecture relies on Hans Jonas to argue that modern technology requires an entirely new ethical framework. Jonas argues that all previous, traditional ethics shared several limitations:

- They were **anthropocentric**, focusing solely on human-to-human interactions.
- They assumed the non-human natural world was invincible and ethically neutral, as human tech was too weak to permanently harm the cosmic order.
- They assumed the human condition and human nature were constant and unchangeable.
- They were “**neighbor**” **ethics**, focused entirely on short-term consequences in the immediate, local present.

The New Imperative and the Heuristics of Fear

Modern technology has obliterated these boundaries. Through its sheer scale, cumulative effects, and irreversibility, technology has made the entire global biosphere an object of human responsibility. Furthermore, humanity itself has become an object of technological reshaping through innovations like life extension, genetic engineering, and electronic behavior control, forcing us to ask what kind of humans we *ought* to be.

Because modern technology propels us toward unpredictable, “utopian” extremes, Jonas formulates a new ethical imperative. Unlike Kant’s categorical imperative, which focuses on the logical consistency of an individual’s present action, Jonas’s imperative is collective and future-oriented: “**Act so that the effects of your action are compatible with the permanence of genuine human life**”.

Ultimately, Jonas argues that our technological power to act has vastly outpaced our power to foresee the long-term consequences. Therefore, ethics must be guided by a “**heuristics of fear**” and a new humility. Recognizing our own ignorance about the ultimate outcomes of our technologies is now a prime ethical duty, compelling us to exercise restraint so that future generations simply have the chance to exist.

10.10 Defining Religion

Class 10 of the “Religions” course transitions from theoretical ethics to the practical application of technology ethics, specifically examining **Ethical Tools**. Drawing primarily from the work of Payam Moula and Per Sandin, the lecture addresses how individuals can systematically navigate complex moral decisions regarding new technologies.

Defining Ethical Tools

While moral philosophers and experts are trained to perform deep ethical analyses, professionals like engineers, medical doctors, and lawyers often need practical assistance to make ethically informed judgments. **Ethical tools** are practical methods or conceptual frameworks designed to help these non-experts improve their ethical deliberations.

Most ethical tools function as more or less sophisticated checklists to ensure that users consider the right aspects, in the right order, and sometimes offer guidelines for weighing those aspects against one another. A basic example is Rotary’s “Four-Way Test,” which asks the user to evaluate an action by asking if it is the truth, fair, goodwill-building, and beneficial to all.

Four Tools in Technology Assessment (TA)

The lecture details four specific ethical tools used to assess the impact of technologies:

1. **The Ethical Matrix (Ben Mepham, 1990s):** This tool creates a grid by tabulating major ethical principles (typically well-being, justice, and autonomy) against relevant stakeholder groups.
 - *Pros:* It is user-friendly and highly effective at helping users map out how different groups are affected by a technology across major ethical theories.
 - *Cons:* It does not help users weigh conflicting considerations to actually reach a final decision, and its “top-down” approach means facilitators might accidentally exclude marginalized stakeholders from the matrix at the outset. To fix the decision-making issue, users can sometimes add a numerical scoring system (from -2 to +2) to the grid.
2. **The Ethical Delphi (Inspired by RAND, 1950s):** This tool facilitates structured, anonymous debate among experts via a virtual committee. Experts exchange views in a series of rounds, with an administrator summarizing the arguments between each round until the subject is thoroughly discussed.
 - *Pros:* It highlights both consensus and disagreement without forcing a unified conclusion. The anonymity neutralizes peer domination and distance.
 - *Cons:* It lacks public transparency (acting like a “black box”), risks bias in how the experts are selected, and might miss considerations if no expert happens to raise them.
3. **The Consensus Conference (Danish Board of Technology, 1980s):** Unlike the Delphi, this tool focuses heavily on public participation. Over several days, a panel of laypeople learns about a technology, selects questions, questions a panel of experts, and then drafts a consensus document outlining their conclusions.
 - *Pros:* It is highly democratic, educates the public, and ensures the public’s views are heard.
 - *Cons:* It risks self-selection bias (as only certain types of people volunteer for such conferences), low attendance, and the danger that minority views are silenced to impose a consensus.
4. **The Convergence Seminar:** A newer tool designed to evaluate emerging technologies and their future uncertainties (such as nanobiotechnology). It relies on “**hypothetical retrospection**”—operating on the logic of “Don’t do that, you may come to regret it!”. Participants break into groups and discuss various continuations of future scenarios across three phases.
 - *Pros:* It is user-friendly and can be completed in just a few hours.
 - *Cons:* Participants are heavily steered toward specific conclusions based on how the pre-written scenarios are framed.

Evaluating Ethical Tools

With so many tools available, the lecture concludes by asking how we evaluate what makes a “good” ethical tool. Three theoretical frameworks are presented:

- **Forsberg’s Stability:** Forsberg argues that a good tool must have *intramethodological stability*—meaning the same user in similar situations should reach the same conclusion, ensuring the tool isn’t just relying on random chance. However, *intermethodological stability* (where different users all reach the exact same conclusion) is actually problematic, as it indicates the tool is overly biased and eliminates the users’ own diverse moral reasoning.
- **Kaiser et al.’s Ethical Soundness:** This framework proposes a strict, binary view where a tool is either ethically sound or unsound. Soundness is judged on criteria like the inclusion of relevant values, transparency, and the exposition of factual and ethical arguments.
- **Moula and Sandin’s Purposiveness:** Rejecting the binary view, Moula and Sandin argue tools should simply be evaluated on **purposiveness**—how well they achieve their specific main and added goals. For instance, a tool meant for public engagement must be evaluated heavily on procedural fairness, whereas a tool strictly meant for decision-making must be evaluated on its ability to logically guide a user to a conclusion.

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